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The Stalled Peace Process

In December 2003, Prime Minister Vajpayee met President General Musharraf on the eve of their annual session of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) in Islamabad, agreeing to a cease-fire along the Line of Control in Kashmir. This important agreement launched the composite peace process for South Asia, designed to put an end to all major conflicts between India and Pakistan. Several positive measures have since been agreed upon, the most symbolically encouraging of which is the Peace Bus that started to travel between Srinagar and Muzaffarabad in 2005, filled with happy Kashmiris, many of whom had not seen their closest relatives for half a century. Significant progress was, it seemed, also made toward agreements to pull all troops off the Siachen Glacier and out of Sir Creek in 2006, though the Indian army stubbornly blocked both of those important resolutions.

Even as this comprehensive peace process inched forward, however, suicide bombers trained by Lashkar-e-Tayiba launched a new series of attacks against India, killing 160 on Mumbai's commuter trains and blowing up buses taking Pakistanis home to Lahore and Islamabad. In Baluchistan, Pakistan's largest and still most turbulent province, eighty-year-old Nawab Akbar Bugti, the region's most popular leader, a friend of Benazir Bhutto, was shot dead inside his own home in Quetta by Pakistani troops on 26 August 2006. Some 170 Baloch "activists" have disappeared since 2000, Pakistan's Human Rights Commission reported, most of them abducted and probably killed by Pakistan's "security forces." Small wonder that Baluchistan has become the home of so many